

PASSWITHPURPOSE

NEW
2027
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Paper 2

Composition Pack

Everything students need for Section B: descriptive and narrative toolkits, 20 exam-style titles, planning sheets, a sentence-upgrade workshop and four annotated model compositions.

- ◆ Descriptive writing toolkit
- ◆ Narrative writing toolkit
- ◆ 20 exam-style titles in 5 sets
- ◆ 2 photocopiable planning sheets
- ◆ Sentence upgrade workshop
- ◆ 4 annotated model compositions
- ◆ Marking bands (40 marks)
- ◆ Self-assessment checklist

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For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All writing is original.

How to use this pack

In Section B of Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) Paper 2, candidates choose **one** of four titles: two descriptive and two narrative. They write about 350–450 words. There is no reading text, so every mark is for writing.

Strand	What examiners look for	Marks
Content & structure	Ideas that are engaging and developed; a clear, deliberate structure; paragraphs that build an effect	16
Style & accuracy	Precise, ambitious vocabulary; varied sentences; control of tense and punctuation; accurate spelling and grammar	24

Descriptive or narrative?

Descriptive	Creates a vivid picture and atmosphere . Little or no plot. The biggest mistake is turning it into a story.
Narrative	Tells a story with one central event, a small cast and a satisfying ending. The biggest mistake is too much plot and too little feeling.

A sequence that works

Lesson 1	Descriptive toolkit → Upgrade workshop → Plan a descriptive title from Set 1
Lesson 2	Read a descriptive model → Write the Set 1 descriptive piece → Self-assess with the checklist
Lesson 3	Narrative toolkit → Plan a narrative title from Set 1 using the story mountain
Lesson 4	Read a narrative model → Write the piece → Peer-mark with the bands
Then	Sets 2–5 for timed practice: 10 minutes planning, 45 minutes writing, 5 minutes checking

BEFORE YOU START: This pack uses the 16/24 split from recent 0500 composition marking. Check the split for 2027 in the current syllabus. The bands in this pack are written for practice marking and are not official Cambridge descriptors.

Descriptive writing toolkit

A five-part structure

1 Wide view	Establish the place, time and mood in a few strong sentences.
2 Zoom in	Focus closely on one small, specific detail: an object, a texture, a sound.
3 Person or movement	Bring in a figure or some motion to give the scene life, without starting a plot.
4 Shift	Change something: time passes, the weather turns, the light fades, the mood alters.
5 Return	Go back to the wide view, now changed. Echo your opening.

Techniques that lift a description

- **Use all five senses**, and make them specific: not “a nice smell”, but “cardamom and diesel”.
- **Precise nouns and verbs** do more than adjectives: “the shutters *rattled*” beats “the very loud shutters”.
- **One controlling image** (e.g. the market as a sleeping animal) holds the piece together.
- **Vary sentences**: a one-line paragraph for impact; long, flowing sentences for movement.
- **Contrast**: light/dark, noise/silence, past/present.
- **Present tense** creates immediacy. Whichever tense you choose, keep it consistent.

Avoid

Plot creep	If a crime, chase or rescue appears, you are writing a story.
Cliché	“Blood-red sun”, “deafening silence”, “the wind howled like a wolf”.
Adjective piles	“The dark, gloomy, scary, eerie house”: choose one precise word instead.
Lists of senses	“I could see... I could hear... I could smell...” Weave the senses in naturally.

20 exam-style titles

Section B • Composition • 40 marks • about 1 hour. Answer **one** question from the set. Write about **350 to 450 words**. Marks are awarded for content and structure and for style and accuracy. Spend about 10 minutes planning.

Practice Set 1

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a busy airport arrivals hall late at night. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a place in the moments before a storm breaks. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story that begins: 'Nobody noticed when the lights went out.' [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story called 'The Return'. [40]

Practice Set 2

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a market as it closes at the end of the day. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe an elderly person's hands, and what they reveal about the life they have lived. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story about a secret that should never have been told. [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story that ends with the words: '...and I never went back.' [40]

Practice Set 3

- 1 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe the view from a high place at dawn. [40]
- 2 **DESCRIPTIVE** Describe a school building during the summer holidays, when it is empty. [40]
- 3 **NARRATIVE** Write a story about a journey that did not go as planned. [40]
- 4 **NARRATIVE** Write a story called 'The Letter'. [40]